

12, he joined the entourage of a Hapsburg general, Ferrante Gonzaga, who took him to Italy. Lassus is then thought to have begun composing during his stays in Mantua, Palermo, Naples, and Milan. By 1553, he was director of music at the cathedral of St. John Lateran in Rome—an elevated post for a man in his early twenties.

In 1555, Lassus returned to the Netherlands, and his first book, a collection of his madrigals, motets, and songs, was published in Antwerp. His name came to the attention of Albrecht V of Bavaria (see [box](#)), who invited him to his court in Munich. Lassus's first official position was as a tenor singer, but by 1563 he was the duke's head of music, a post he would hold for the rest of his life. He married a maid of honor at the court, Regina Wäckinger; their two sons would both grow up to be composers.

A Renaissance sensation

Lassus supplied secular music for the court and sacred music for its chapel. Some of his music was reserved for the duke's exclusive enjoyment—Lassus was not allowed to publish his much-admired Penitential Psalms until after the duke's death. But a large part of the composer's prodigious output appeared in print. It has been estimated that more than half of all the music published in Europe in the second half of the 16th century was by Lassus. Some of his works gained popularity well beyond the restricted circle of royal courts. He traveled widely, recruiting singers for the Munich establishment and supervising performances of his work. Lassus's appearance at the court of the French king Charles IX in 1571 caused such a sensation that he